

SOCIAL SCIENCE

OUR PASTS – III

Textbook in History
for Class VIII



0864

विद्यया ऽ मृतमश्नुते



एन सी ई आर टी
NCERT

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FOREWORD

The National Curriculum Framework, 2005, recommends that children's life at school must be linked to their life outside the school. This principle marks a departure from the legacy of bookish learning which continues to shape our system and causes a gap between the school, home and community. The syllabi and textbooks developed on the basis of NCF signify an attempt to implement this basic idea. They also attempt to discourage rote learning and the maintenance of sharp boundaries between different subject areas. We hope these measures will take us significantly further in the direction of a child-centred system of education outlined in the National Policy on Education (1986).

The success of this effort depends on the steps that school principals and teachers will take to encourage children to reflect on their own learning and to pursue imaginative activities and questions. We must recognise that, given space, time and freedom, children generate new knowledge by engaging with the information passed on to them by adults. Treating the prescribed textbook as the sole basis of examination is one of the key reasons why other resources and sites of learning are ignored. Inculcating creativity and initiative is possible if we perceive and treat children as participants in learning, not as receivers of a fixed body of knowledge.

These aims imply considerable change in school routines and mode of functioning. Flexibility in the daily time-table is as necessary as rigour in implementing the annual calendar so that the required number of teaching days are actually devoted to teaching. The methods used for teaching and evaluation will also determine how effective this textbook proves for making children's life at school a happy experience, rather than a source of stress or boredom. Syllabus designers have tried to address the problem of curricular burden by restructuring and reorienting knowledge at different stages with greater consideration for child psychology and the time available for teaching. The textbook attempts to enhance this endeavor by giving higher priority and space to opportunities for contemplation and wondering, discussion in small groups, and activities requiring hands-on experience.

NCERT appreciates the hard work done by the textbook development committee responsible for this book. We wish to thank the Chairperson of the Advisory Committee for Textbook in Social Science, Professor Hari Vasudevan and the Chief Advisor for this book, Professor Neeladri Bhattacharya for guiding the work of this committee. Several teachers contributed to the development of this textbook; we are grateful to their principals for making this possible. We are indebted to the institutions and organisations, which have generously permitted us to draw upon their resources, material and personnel. We are especially grateful to the members of the National Monitoring Committee, appointed by the Department of

Secondary and Higher Education, Ministry of Human Resource Development under the Chairpersonship of Professor Mrinal Miri and Professor G. P. Deshpande, for their valuable time and contribution. As an organisation committed to systemic reform and continuous improvement in the quality of its products, NCERT welcomes comments and suggestions which will enable us to undertake further revision and refinement.

New Delhi
30 November 2007

Director
National Council of Educational
Research and Training

RATIONALISATION OF CONTENT IN THE TEXTBOOKS

In view of the COVID-19 pandemic, it is imperative to reduce content load on students. The National Education Policy 2020, also emphasises reducing the content load and providing opportunities for experiential learning with creative mindset. In this background, the NCERT has undertaken the exercise to rationalise the textbooks across all classes. Learning Outcomes already developed by the NCERT across classes have been taken into consideration in this exercise.

Contents of the textbooks have been rationalised in view of the following:

- Overlapping with similar content included in other subject areas in the same class
- Similar content included in the lower or higher class in the same subject
- Difficulty level
- Content, which is easily accessible to students without much interventions from teachers and can be learned by children through self-learning or peer-learning
- Content, which is irrelevant in the present context

This present edition, is a reformatted version after carrying out the changes given above.

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The book is the product of a collective effort of a large number of historians, educationists and teachers. The chapters were written and revised over several months. They evolved through discussions in workshops, and exchange of ideas through emails, with each member contributing their skill in many different ways. All of us learnt a lot in the process.

Many individuals and institutions helped in the production of the book. Professor Muzaffar Alam and Dr Kumkum Roy read drafts and offered suggestions for change. We drew upon the image collections of several institutions in illustrating the book. A number of photographs of the city of Delhi and of the events of 1857 are from the Alkazi Foundation for the Arts. Many of the nineteenth-century illustrated books on the British Raj are to be found in the valuable India Collection of the India International Centre. We are particularly glad that Sunil Janah, now 90 years of age, has given us permission to reproduce his photographs. From the early 1940s, he has explored the tribal areas and recorded with his camera the daily life of different communities. Some of these photographs are now published (*The Tribals of India*, Oxford University of Press, 2003), and many are at the Indira Gandhi National Centre for Arts.

Shalini Advani and Shyama Warner have done several rounds of editing with care and understanding, suggesting changes, tracking mistakes and improving the text in innumerable ways. We thank them both for their involvement in the project.

The Council acknowledges the valuable inputs for analysing syllabi, textbooks and the content, proposed to be rationalised for this edition by Umesh Ashok Kadam, *Professor*, Centre for Historical Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi; Sunil Kumar Singh, *PGT History*, Kendriya Vidyalaya, AFS, Tughlakabad, New Delhi; Krishna Ranjan, *PGT History*, Kendriya Vidyalaya, Vikaspuri; Archana Verma, *Associate Professor*, Department of History, Hindu College, University of Delhi, Delhi; Shruti Mishra, *PGT History* and *HoD*, History, Delhi Public School, R.K. Puram, New Delhi; Gouri Srivastava, *Professor* and *Head*, Pratyusa K. Mandal, *Professor*; Seema S. Ojha, *Professor*, DESS; Mily Roy Anand, *Professor*, DGS and Sharad Kumar Pandey, *Associate Professor*, DCS&D, NCERT.

We have made every effort to acknowledge credits, but we apologise in advance for any omission that may have inadvertently taken place.

FOR EXTENDED LEARNING



0864PCVI

You may access the following chapters through QR Code.

- Colonialism and the City
- The Changing World of Visual Arts.

These chapters were printed in the previous textbooks, the same are being provided in digital mode for extended learning.

CREDITS

Individuals

Sunil Janah (Ch. 4, Figs. 4, 8, 9, 10)

Institutions

Nehru Memorial Museum and Library, New Delhi (Ch. 6, Figs. 4, 5, 7, 13)

Photo Division, Government of India, New Delhi (Ch. 8, Fig. 20)

The Alkazi Foundation for the Arts (Ch. 5, Fig. 11)

Victoria Memorial Museum (Ch. 5, Fig. 1)

Journals

The Illustrated London News (Ch. 6, Fig. 15)

Books

Andreas Volwahren, *Imperial Delhi: The British Capital of the Indian Empire* (Ch. 1, Fig. 4)

C.A. Bayly, ed., *An Illustrated History of Modern India, 1600-1947* (Ch. 1, Fig. 1; Ch. 2, Figs. 5, 12; Ch. 3, Fig. 1, Ch. 7, Figs. 3, 4, 5, 10)

Colesworthy Grant, *Rural Life in Bengal* (Ch. 3, Figs. 8, 9, 11, 12, 13)

Colin Campbell, *Narrative of the Indian Revolt from its Outbreak to the Capture of Lucknow* (Ch. 5, Figs. 3, 5, 6, 7, 8)

Gautam Bhadra, *From an Imperial Product to a National Drink: The Culture of Tea Consumption in Modern India* (Ch. 1, Fig. 2)

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Susan Stronge, ed., *The Arts of the Sikh Kingdom* (Ch. 2, Fig. 11)

Tiziana and Gianni Baldizzone, *Hidden Tribes of India* (Ch. 4, Figs. 1, 2, 5, 6, 7)

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The British Resident at the court of Poona concluding a treaty, 1790